

rewards, it doesn't decrease when you avoid them (i.e., no-spend challenge), so you must also focus on calming your survival brain down so your logical brain can get a word in.

We'll look at five of the ways the reward center of our brain (aka instant gratification) can overpower our logical brain and how to support our minds so we can make better real-time spending decisions.

Habit Spending

After college, our friend Paige got a job at a car dealership. She only worked there a year, but in that year she spent almost her entire paycheck, over \$60,000 on . . . stuff. Clothes, accessories, handbags, anything she could buy at the mall. It started as a way to assimilate into her new identity as a working woman in the corporate world. "As silly and crazy as this sounds, I vividly remember thinking that I needed a closet that looked like Jennifer Garner's in *13 Going on 30* or Anne Hathaway's in *Devil Wears Prada*. I thought it was going to make me feel a certain way about myself. And it just didn't." She quickly realized that car sales were not for her. Buying her new work wardrobe was fun, though, so she kept going to the mall every day on her lunch break to escape the job she hated. She'd go four out of five days each week and buy something every time. After a year, it didn't even give her pleasure anymore, it was just a habit.

After going through your 90-day transaction inventory, you may have found quite a few purchases you have little to no memory of. I know I did. The latte I got on the way to see my mom, the lunch I got whenever I passed my favorite Chipotle, the beers I bought with friends when I didn't even really like beer! These purchases did absolutely nothing for me except continue a habit I didn't know I had. Habit change isn't easy, but it is a great place to start because most of these transactions, while they may have started as a way to purchase a new identity or escape a job you hate, after a while aren't tied to a deeper meaning.

If you've read any books on habits or ever Googled how to build better habits, you've probably been introduced to the Habit Loop: Cue → Routine → Reward. All our behaviors are triggered by a cue and followed by a routine that ends in a reward. Our brain remembers the reward, thanks to dopamine and the limbic system, and the next time it encounters the cue,